**DEM. REP. OF CONGO****Capital city:** Kinshasa**Area:** 905,563 sq miles  
(2,345,410 sq km)**Population:** 52,800,000**Official language:** French**Major religions:**Christian 70%, Muslim  
10%, traditional beliefs  
10%, other 10%**Government:** Multiparty  
democracy**Currency:** Congolese franc**Adult literacy rate:** 63%**Life expectancy:** 45 years**People per doctor:** 10,000**Televisions:** 135 per 1,000  
people

# DEMOCRATIC REPUBLIC OF THE CONGO

ASIDE FROM A TINY FINGER of land that stretches to the coast, the vast country of the Democratic Republic of Congo is landlocked. The Congo River snakes its way through the country, providing a watery lifeline for its people. The climate is warm and wet, and most people are farmers. Since independence from Belgium in 1960, the Democratic Republic of the Congo has suffered from civil war, a harsh dictator, and falling prices for its products. These problems have made it one of the world's poorest countries.



A hydroelectric dam has been built on the Congo at Inga. The dam harnesses the power of the water to create electricity.

Tugboat pushing logs along the river

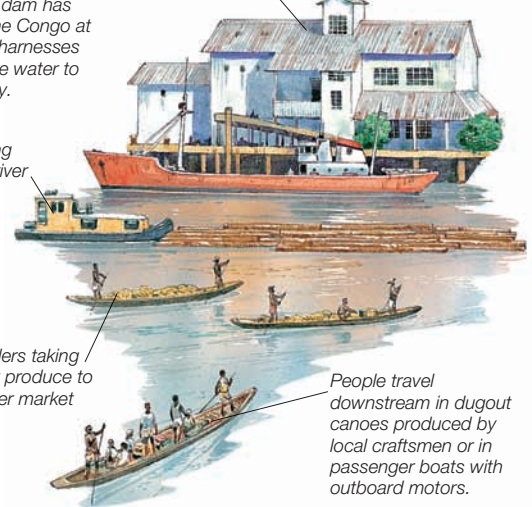


Shells sewn onto material made from vegetable fibers

**AFRICAN ART**

The Democratic Republic of the Congo is famous for its distinctive art. The Kuba people of the country's central region, whose ancestors date back many centuries, use shells, beads, and raffia (fibers from palm leaves) to create geometric patterns. A Kuba chief would have worn the haunting mask shown above in order to take on some of the power of a great spirit.

Boats stop at river ports for repair work and to refuel.



Traders taking their produce to a river market

People travel downstream in dugout canoes produced by local craftsmen or in passenger boats with outboard motors.

## CONGO RIVER

The people here call the Congo River the Zaire. One of the largest rivers in the world, this wide ribbon of water forms the nation's transportation system, cutting a great upside-down "U" through miles of forest. People traveling from place to place crowd into motorized boats and dugout canoes. Some large boats are even floating health clinics or bars. The river's fish provide vital food, while crops are grown on the fertile riverbanks.

### The course of the Congo River



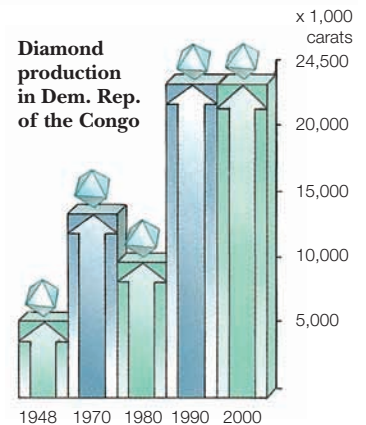
The curving Congo River crosses the Equator twice.

## MINING WEALTH

The Democratic Republic of the Congo's mining industry seems to hold the key to greater wealth in the future. There are vast seams of copper, cobalt, gold, uranium, silver, and diamonds here, and reserves of oil lie just off the coast. Copper mining, shown below, is very important, but when the price of copper fell in the 1970s, the economy virtually collapsed.



### Diamond production in Dem. Rep. of the Congo



The Democratic Republic of the Congo is one of the biggest producers of diamonds in the world. Together with copper and cobalt, they provide over 85% of the country's export earnings.

### Find out more

COPPER MINING: 73, 245

DIAMONDS: 150, 226, 248

HYDROELECTRICITY: 108, 262

POLITICAL SYSTEMS: 270-271

**MARKETS**

Colorful, bustling river ports are meeting points for trade and travel along the Congo River. Stores selling travel provisions or farming tools nestle alongside markets where people from riverside villages come to sell their goods. Markets are not only based on land. Traders often sell their fresh vegetables and fish directly from their dugout canoes.